been confident of his ability to sell his ideas to the Directors. But it cannot be denied that it was also his lack of ego and enthusiasm for the cause of reviving swadeshi banking institutions which played a role in the decision.

Sir Pherozeshah's association with the bank gave it status; in him the bank secured a Chairman who brought with him great public prestige and patriotic appeal. With his entry, the climate of opinion began to swing in favour of the fledging institution, offsetting at least in part the damage done by the failure of the Bank of Burma. Sorabji's choice was indeed a happy one, for no other personality could have more aptly symbolized his aspiration of a bank run by Indians, for Indians. It is interesting to note that the greater part of Sorabji's early life paralleled the development of swadeshi between 1880 and 1900. The main emphasis in swadeshi was political, while for Sorabji the political motive was incidental. In this he shared something in common with his famous contemporary, Ardeshir Godrej, one of the early pioneers who realized that swadeshi was integral to Swaraj.[11] If India wanted to be independent, then the mere boycott of British goods was not sufficient: she had to produce goods of equal, if not superior quality. While Godrej was far more vociferous and aggressive about swadeshi, both realized that while political domination is obvious, economic domination is less visible but equally pernicious. The success of the Tata Iron and Steel Company (TISCO), founded in 1907, in getting its entire capital subscribed by Indians within three months illustrates the spirit prevailing at the time. But the Central Bank's origins lay almost exclusively in Sorabji's desire to establish a banking institution in which Indians would be the masters of their own destiny. As S.K. Muranjan observed, 'The Central Bank of India was launched into existence in December 1911 mainly by the untiring efforts and banking genius of Sorabji Pochkhanawala whose life history belongs to the regions of romance in banking and finance.'[12]

Sorabji's way of fighting the prevailing prejudice was by challenging and disproving the premise that Europeans had an exclusive monopoly of managerial talent. Like Godrej, Sorabji also believed that politics devoted solely to acquire political freedom was an empty concept if not backed by economic power. He believed that national regeneration and financial autonomy were inseparable. Sorabji had to fight the deeply entrenched notion that 'native gentleman' would be unable to conduct a bank according